

Episode 20: Once Upon a Time... (15) *Saint Seiya* Part 2 – Episode 1, and OP & ED Stories

Last Saturday night, I got an email on my cell phone from a female acquaintance (25, single). From Narita Airport no less! "I thought the excitement before my first overseas trip departure could only be conveyed now, so I'm emailing." Ah, that's right. That day was her very first overseas trip ever.

The feeling when you've passed immigration and are waiting at the departure gate looking at your plane through the window - that indescribable strange heart flutter of anxiety and anticipation. And it's her first time! Reading that email, this old man found himself getting gentle eyes (laughs).

Then Sunday late night, Tokyo region broadcast the latest *Suiyou Dou Deshou Ka* (Wednesday How About It). I was watching while working at the studio, and ah, it's Europe! Rome, Vatican, Florence! Ah, I want to go after so long!

The new passport I picked up recently has no scheduled use yet. Actually, I took a week off early this month. I wanted to go to Brussels and Antwerp. But I ended up just relaxing in Tokyo (bitter laugh).

I want to go out somewhere by maybe next month... Ah, maybe impossible. Then, then at least in autumn... (distant stare).

Well then.

"*Saint Seiya* Episode 1". Script: **Koyama Takao**, Storyboard & Direction: **Morishita Kozo**, Animation Director: **Araki Shingo**, Art Director: **Kubota Tadao**.**

Toei Doga's TV series finishing system at this time assigned one "inspection" member as the person in charge of each work, but usually they only handled

programmes startup and later-appearing "main treatment" character colouring settings (so-called "colour direction sheets"), with per-episode colour direction requested from production companies handling that episode's finishing.

As I wrote earlier, basically character colour direction was also handled by art, so guest character colours appearing in each episode were all specified by art director Kubota-san, with per-episode finishing production companies communicating with art through art department progress to decide.

For example, guest characters appearing in #3 who then appear in several subsequent episodes would get OK from the first episode's direction, then that OK colour direction would be passed to the next episode's production company, and so on. Usually colours from art were OK as-is, so art's specifications - copies with paint numbers noted on character design drawings - would circulate as-is as colour direction sheets.

As an aside, due to such systems, most early *Saint Seiya* episode guest characters lack properly organised colour direction sheets. Toei Doga didn't place "setting production" then or now (assistant directors managed it), so colour direction got quite scattered.

Also, because of such colour direction sheets, there were many colouring mistakes. Unlike now where colour designers check all episodes, things other than properly organised main characters were OK if consistent within that episode and production company.

However, Episode 1 and opening/ending were handled by internal inspection, so Episode 1 was basic - the series standard. But Episode 1 is the very first, so following direction instructions for colour direction was all I could do. I had no capacity to think about later episodes back then (bitter laugh). Just adding colour direction to in-between animation coming to me one after another.

Also back then, we weren't allowed to check TV series finishing deliveries. Delivered cels went directly from finishing progress to **saridashi** (compositing), with assistant directors checking before **saridashi** if time allowed. So colour mistakes and such would only become retakes after being photographed and becoming rush film, or when lined up and connected during editing (well, this system basically hasn't changed even now (bitter laugh)). We often weren't even invited to rushes.

So, Episode 1.

Actually, before writing this, I secretly rewatched Episode 1 on DVD. Ah, I don't remember much detail about this Episode 1 main story, actually (bitter laugh). Since I was completely unaccustomed to "image-style screen direction," I just remember constantly taking cuts to ask **Morishita-san** about everything.

For example, "Shaina-san's 'Thunder Claw' cobra image scene" and such. Image backgrounds with this animation - what kind of screen would it be as cel, how would it look with transmitted light added in photography? I couldn't really imagine it, so I remember just groping through specifications.

Rewatching reminded me that pupil highlight processing wasn't finalised yet. Also **Pegasus Saint Cloth (聖衣)** highlight processing. How to process highlights on white, like **Marin's** mask highlights - trial and error (laughs).

I remember opening and ending work better than Episode 1 main story. Opening and ending broadcast every episode had to be made properly, so I was made to check all of this.

Incidentally, opening and ending were shot on 35mm film (main story used 16mm film). This was because many prints had to be made, and staff and lyrics text had

to be optically composited. So even using the same materials (cels, backgrounds), opening and ending had finer grain than main story images.

"Red, right, ground shadow. X-28, right." These are **Morishita-san's** words. About ground shadows under the Saints running toward us in the opening's first cut. This was Morishita-san's first words at the opening colour direction meeting. When paints were used for colouring, we'd communicate colours and colour nuances using paint numbers as common vocabulary like this. So, "X-28, right." Incidentally, blood-like vivid red.

The Seiya Cloth equipping cut shared with main story used main story cut animation, but Araki-san personally changed timesheet frame timing, removed some animation cels, and used it for opening with strong/weak tempo.

Opening and ending work came after Episode 1 work was finished, and we were pressed for time. Cels painted at the last minute had colour mistakes, and I have memories of repainting large cels alone at the large-format light table for late-night colouring (laughs).

Colour mismatches appeared in rushes completed at the last minute, but there was no time to fix them, so they became "lifelong embarrassing retake #1" (bitter laugh). In an ending cut where large cel hair flowing was on repeat, cel misalignment couldn't be fixed until the end, becoming "lifelong embarrassing retake #2" (bitter laugh).

Near the end of the opening, the Athena statue rising from below cut. The Athena statue's shadow colours were painted differently in the cut's first and second halves, and I secretly OK'd it as-is - that's a secret (laughs).

Oh, I think Episode 1 also had quite a few dousa (in-between animation photography) cuts? "Dousa came out (sweat)," we were all panicking. **Gensan** (original photography) and layout photography being commonplace now makes it somewhat cute (laughs).

Anyway, *Saint Seiya* Episode 1 was completed this way.

When the first screening ended and he stood up, Chief Director Morishita-san said one thing: "That's it. This will be cancelled after 2 cours."

That *Saint Seiya* would become a huge hit work.

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